Why do we buy into the 'cult' of overwork?
By Bryan Lufkin
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Overwork isn't a phenomenon exclusive to Silicon Valley or Wall Street. People work long hours all over the world, for many different reasons.

Some of the earliest researchers on burnout in the 1970s asserted that many people in jobs geared toward helping others, like employees in clinics or crisis-intervention centres, tended to work long hours that led to emotional and physical exhaustion – a trend that's shown up in the pandemic, too.

But millions of us overwork because somehow we think it's exciting – a status symbol that puts us on the path to success, whether we define that by wealth or an Instagram post that makes it seem like we're living a dream life with a dream job.

Yet even though we're working harder than ever, and young workers are faced with a potentially toxic combination of greater financial pressures (student debt, combined with lower salaries and higher house prices), pressure to find 'their passion' and pressure to find a stable job in an increasingly insecure job market, there may be some small signs of change.

And as grueling as the pandemic has been, it's also forced us to see work-life balance in a whole new way. Last month, LinkedIn conducted a survey of more than 5,000 users over two weeks: 50% and 45% of respondents say that hours or location flexibility and work-life balance respectively have become more important to them since the pandemic.
"The pandemic has been powerful not only in making salient many of the things that matter most – health, family, relationships – and in disrupting some of the routines and systems that were keeping people on the treadmill," says Maitlis.

In response, some companies have begun talking about offering more robust mental-health programmes for workers, including perks like complimentary therapy sessions or free access to wellness apps. Yet, experts think it is highly unlikely that we're entering a new era that prioritises wellbeing over overwork.

At the end of the day, companies want to make money. "We dehumanised the workplace a long time ago, and I'm not saying it with any pride," says Lechner. For many companies, it's still: "If you don't work, then someone else will come along and do it.

We're at a crossroads: we can prioritise our wellbeing, or prioritise sending an email at 0300 because it'll impress the boss. Letting people work from home can only go so far in easing the burden – it has to be up to the workers to stop making burnout somehow desirable, and up to the companies to stop making the workers feel like they should.

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